

An artisan working on leather and two foreigners look on.

Things Beautiful... and Cheap

AN old man bends over small pieces of leather wielding a pocket knife. Around him are sophisticated leather bags, wallets, belts and key chains crafted ingeniously to reveal a strong sense of design and style.

Nearby, a young weaver works on a simple wooden loom with great finesse and produces a colourful floor rug. He uses both wool and cotton blending natural earth colours in a lively combination to create a dramatic effect.

The two craftsmen belong to an economically backward area of Rajasthan known as Jawaja, and demonstrated their skilled craftsmanship at an exhibition sponsored by the Crafts Council of India at the Lalit Kala Akademi in Madras recently. What was interesting about the exhibition was that without neglecting the artistic value of the crafts, emphasis was given to the idea that a craft is still in many parts of India the only source of economic sustenance for a family and as such its value lies in its marketability and utility as much as it does in its appeal as an art object.

The leather workers in Jawaja were traditionally involved in earning a livelihood from making 'juthas' (a particular kind of footwear) and 'charas' (small pouches). Unequipped with literary skills, they had no idea of market values, nor the awareness that to survive in a world of constantly changing demands, they would have to move beyond the narrow range of their particular products and adapt their skills to suit altered tastes and times. Thus the typical 'jutha' makers of Jawaja were beginning to find that their craft was slowly dying and along with it their means of existence.

The Indian Institute of Management in Ahmedabad collaborated with the Education department of the Government of Rajasthan and introduced an 'earn-while-you-learn' scheme in Jawaja.

The area comprises 200 villages with a population of about 85,000 and is either always drought ridden or flood prone with very little scope for irrigation and the cultivation of crops.

Consequently the dependence on crafts is crucial in this part of Rajasthan.

The project has injected fresh life into the old crafts by harnessing the craftsmen's skills in a meaningful direction and enabling them to successfully evade exploitation by middlemen and develop a sense of self-reliance.

The new process and techniques in weaving or leather fabrication are not fraught with the usual complexities of the machine age. Tools are still basic enough to match the simplicity of the craft. What the craftsmen have acquired is a necessary flexibility in design and method which allows them to adapt to the changing scope of their craft.

The encouragement to experiment in new directions comes from places like the National Institute of Design and the Central Leather Research Institute. The IIM has also appointed a project co-ordinator in every village who is readily available for help with any problems that the craftsmen may encounter from time to time.

Speaking of his experiences with the project Mr. Behrulal the weaver said, "I have learned a lot about the power of my craft from being involved in this project. Not only have I realised how I can make my art flourish for its own sake but I have acquired an understanding of market systems, accounting, how to procure materials and above all how to create something that is not only beautiful but also useful and consequently more meaningful".

The Crafts Council of India's role has been to emphasise this meaningfulness of crafts in India. Mrs. Radha Panniker of the Crafts Council said, "The old Indian always surrounded himself with beautiful things which were also always useful things. Today we are losing our traditional ties with beauty, by forsaking our crafts. The Crafts Council's role lies mainly in bringing the genuine craftsman together with the consumer and bypassing the middleman".

The stress is on the preservation of crafts through updated techniques not only for their intrinsic value but for the fact that they constitute the only means of livelihood for a great majority of craftsmen.

The exhibition of the Jawaja crafts has also pricked a long standing bubble which projected an idea that arts and crafts are exclusive to the elite.

Mrs. Panniker said "We are very conscious about pricing articles reasonably. Our object is to bring the beauty of craft into every home because we want to emphasise that beautiful things can be cheap".

The Jawaja craftsmen deal directly with their customers through marketing avenues set up by the IIM or through institutions like the Crafts Council whose exhibition fostered an awareness among the public about the individuality and creativity of rural crafts which are not only a vital economic activity in many parts of our country but form an integral part of our artistic heritage.

Our Special Correspondent

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